Dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB): what is it and what causes it?

Dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB) is a type of dementia caused by Lewy bodies, which are clumps of protein in the cells of the brain. Read more about what DLB is, and who gets the condition.

1. Dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB): what is it and what causes it?
2. Getting a diagnosis of dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB)
3. Symptoms of dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB)
4. Treatments and support for dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB)
5. Dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB) – useful resources

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What is dementia with Lewy bodies?

Dementia is caused by different diseases that affect the brain. Lewy body dementia is caused by Lewy body disease.

In this disease, tiny clumps of proteins known as Lewy bodies appear in the nerve cells of the brain. Lewy bodies are named after FH Lewy, the German doctor who first identified them.

Lewy bodies cause a range of symptoms, some of which are shared by Alzheimer's disease and some by Parkinson's disease. For this reason, DLB is often wrongly diagnosed. About 1 in 10 people with dementia has DLB.

Watch this short video about dementia with Lewy bodies:

What causes dementia with Lewy bodies?

It is not yet known why Lewy bodies develop in the brain or exactly how they cause dementia. But we do know that Lewy body disease:

- can cause different symptoms depending on what parts of the brain have the biggest build-up of faulty proteins
- reduces the levels of important chemicals needed to send messages around the brain
- breaks the connections between nerve cells, eventually causing these cells to stop working
- usually develops over a period of many years – typically when a person is approaching old age. Lewy bodies can be developing in the brain for a long time before any symptoms show.

Having Lewy body disease doesn't mean that a person's dementia is only caused by the build-up of Lewy bodies in their brain.

Many people with DLB also have a build-up of other proteins that cause Alzheimer's disease. This is common in people over about 80 years old. For people with both DLB and Alzheimer's, dementia symptoms are often more severe and progress more quickly.

Parkinson's disease

Parkinson's disease is also caused by a build-up of Lewy bodies in the brain. DLB has a lot of symptoms in common with Parkinson's disease. Both cause problems with:

- thinking
- movement
- mood
- how well the body works.

In DLB, the symptoms of dementia begin before or around the same time as the person develops problems with movement.

For people with Parkinson's disease, symptoms of dementia often develop many years after the movement problems begin.

Who gets dementia with Lewy bodies?

Around 5% of people with a diagnosis of dementia are recorded as having DLB, but there is good evidence that the condition is under-diagnosed. Scientists think DLB may account for up to 20% of all dementia.

Dementia with Lewy bodies affects men and women roughly equally. As with most other types of dementia, DLB becomes increasingly common over the age of 65. It can also affect people younger than this.

There is not much evidence that anything we might be exposed to during our lives increases the risk of DLB. Having a traumatic head injury (or repeated injuries) may increase the risk of developing Parkinson's disease later in life, but it's not known whether this also applies to DLB.

Almost all people who develop DLB have a 'sporadic' form, which means that the main cause is unknown. Some genes may increase the risk of developing DLB.

Meg and Keith's experience of dementia with Lewy bodies and Parkinson's disease dementia

Real stories

Adjusting to life after diagnosis is challenging for people living with dementia and their carers. Meg Wilkes explains the impact of her husband Keith's move into residential care, following his diagnosis of dementia with Lewy bodies.

08 June 2018

Advice

Can genes cause dementia?

Around 1 in 4 people aged 55 years and over has a close birth relative with dementia. Find out what part genes play in dementia and how genetics can affect the risk of developing the condition.

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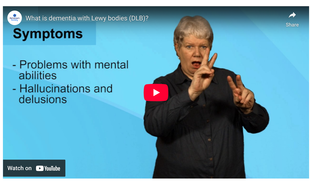

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‹ Previous Section
You are on the first page

Next Section ›
2. Getting a diagnosis of dementia with Lewy bodies (DLB)

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First Valentine's Day after the death of a spouse: Emily's dementia story

Real stories

Emily and Jim were married for nearly 50 years. Jim had been diagnosed with Lewy Bodies dementia, and recently passed away. Emily shares the importance of making and treasuring memories, and how the first Valentine's Day without your spouse feels.

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Dementia with Lewy bodies needs better health care at every level

Real stories

Kerry Hine, whose late husband had dementia with Lewy bodies, says people affected by the condition need improved support.

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Researching drugs for dementia with Lewy bodies and Parkinson's disease dementia

Research

A new trial called COBALT is looking for people with dementia with Lewy bodies or Parkinson's disease dementia to see if using two drugs together could help improve their symptoms.

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